



**Shared immortality:** Across cricket and tennis, Sachin Tendulkar and Roger Federer made excellence seem timeless, until time, inevitably, proved otherwise. GETTYIMAGES

yourself these are manageable, that life is carrying on, that the body can be bargained with.

But then you watch Modric labour where once he floated, or Ronaldo rage against the limits of legs that no longer answer every call, and that illusion breaks a little. If they can fade, then what chance do the rest of us have? These men were supposed to outlast ordinary rules. We were the mortals.

That, perhaps, is why sport's greatest stars matter beyond medals and numbers. They do not simply

entertain us; they become markers of our own passage through life. We remember where we were when Tendulkar made that hundred, when Federer glided through another Wimbledon fortnight, when Nadal clawed through another five-set war, when Ronaldo leapt above defenders as though gravity could be compromised, when Messi finally dribbled his way to a World Cup.

They become companions to our years. Their careers are the thread that stitches together school and work, first love and heartbreak, new cities and old friendships, parents growing older and children growing up. And so, when they begin to disappear, it is never only their ending we are mourning. It is the passing of our own seasons, too.

Maybe that is the ache running

through every World Cup now. Beneath the tactics and scorelines, beneath the noise of a new generation arriving, there is the unmistakable sense of an era loosening its grip.

The old giants are disappearing, one by one, leaving behind only the echoes of what they once made feel routine. Whether Messi's final chapter ends in triumph or defeat almost feels beside the point. Every ending reminds us that another piece of our own sporting life is passing into memory.

And perhaps that is enough for now. One last run. One last attempt to hold the darkness off a little longer. One last tournament in which the old gods can still be glimpsed in the light, even if the light is beginning to fade.